

Visitor Visa

Overview

Generally, a citizen of a foreign country who wishes to travel to the United States must first obtain a visa, either a nonimmigrant visa for a temporary stay, or an immigrant visa for permanent residence. Visitor visas are nonimmigrant visas for persons who want to enter the United States temporarily for business (B-1 visa), for tourism (B-2 visa), or for a combination of both purposes (B-1/B-2 visa).

Here are some examples of activities permitted with a visitor visa:

TOURISM(B-2)

- Tourism
- Vacation (holiday)
- Visit with friends or relatives
- Medical treatment
- Participation in social events hosted by fraternal, social, or service organizations
- Participation by amateurs in musical, sports, or similar events or contests, if not being paid for participating
- Enrollment in a short recreational course of study, not for credit toward a degree (for example, a two-day cooking class while on vacation)

Travel Purposes Not permitted on visitor visa.

These are some examples of activities that require different categories of visas and cannot be done while on a visitor visa:

- Study
- Employment
- Paid performances, or any professional performance before a paying audience
- Arrival as a crewmember on a ship or aircraft
- Work as foreign press, in radio, film, print journalism, or other information media
- Permanent residence in the United States

Birth tourism (travel for the primary purpose of giving birth in the United States to obtain U.S. citizenship for their child) is not permissible on a visitor visa.

BUSINESS(B-1)

You may be eligible for a B-1 visa if you will be participating in business activities of a commercial or professional nature in the United States, including, but not limited to:

- Consulting with business associates
- Traveling for a scientific, educational, professional or business convention, or a conference on specific dates
- Settling an estate
- Negotiating a contract
- Participating in short-term training
- Transiting through the United States: certain persons may transit the United States with a B-1 visa
- Deadheading: certain air crewmen may enter the United States as deadhead crew with a B-1 visa

ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENTS

You must demonstrate the following in order to be eligible for a B-1 and B-2 visa:

- The purpose of your trip is to enter the United States for business of a legitimate nature
- You plan to remain for a specific limited period of time
- You have sufficient funds to cover the expenses of the trip and your stay in the United States
- You have a residence outside the United States that you have no intention of abandoning, as well as other binding ties that will ensure your return abroad at the end of the visit
- You are otherwise admissible to the United States

TRAVEL FOR MEDICAL TREATMENT

If you are seeking medical treatment in the United States, the consular officer may ask for further documents at your visa interview, which may include:

- Medical diagnosis from a local physician, explaining the nature of the ailment and the reason you need treatment in the United States.
- Letter from a physician or medical facility in the United States, stating they are willing to treat your specific ailment and detailing the projected length and cost of treatment (including doctors' fees, hospitalization fees, and all medical-related expenses).
- Proof that your transportation, medical, and living expenses in the United States will be paid. This may be in the form of bank or other statements of income/savings or certified copies of income tax returns (either yours or the person or organization paying for your treatment).

How to Apply

There are several steps to apply for a visa. The order of these steps and how you complete them may vary by U.S. Embassy or Consulate. Please consult the instructions on the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate website](#).

1. Complete the Online Visa Application

- Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application, [Form DS-160](#) – You must: 1) complete the online visa application and 2) print the application form confirmation page to bring to your interview. The DS-160, Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application form, is for temporary travel to the United States, and for K (fiancé(e)) visas. Form DS-160 is submitted electronically to the Department of State website via the Internet. Consular Officers use the information entered on the DS-160 to process the visa application and, combined with a personal interview, determine an applicant's eligibility for a nonimmigrant visa.
- Visa applicants must submit a completed DS-160, Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application for all nonimmigrant visa categories

Important Notice to Visa Applicants: After you have completed the DS-160, you must take these next steps below:

- Print and keep the DS-160 barcode page. (You will not need to print the full application.)
- You must schedule a visa interview appointment. (The U.S. Embassy or Consulate does not schedule an appointment for you.) Visit the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) website where you will be interviewed for country-specific instructions.;
- Pay the visa application processing fee. Review country-specific instructions on the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) website.
- Photo – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160.

2. Schedule an Interview

Interviews are generally required for visa applicants with certain limited exceptions. Consular officers may require an interview of any visa applicant.

You should generally schedule an appointment for your visa interview at the U.S. Embassy or Consulate in the country where you live. You may schedule your interview at another U.S. Embassy or Consulate where you will be present but aware that in some cases it may be more difficult to demonstrate your qualifications for a visa outside of the country where you live.

Wait times for interview appointments vary by location, season, and visa category, so you should apply for your visa early. Review the interview wait time for the location where you will apply:

3.Prepare for Your Interview

- Fees - Pay the non-refundable visa application fee, if you are required to pay it before your interview. If your visa is approved, you may also need to pay a visa issuance fee, if applicable to your nationality.

4.Gather Required Documentation

- Gather and prepare the following required documents before your visa interview:
- Passport valid for travel to the United States – Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your period of stay in the United States (unless exempt by country-specific agreements). Each individual who needs a visa must submit a separate application, including any family members listed in your passport.
- Nonimmigrant Visa Application, Form DS-160 confirmation page.
- Application fee payment receipt, if you are required to pay before your interview.
- Photo – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. If the photo upload fails, you must bring one printed photo in the format explained in the Photograph Requirements.
- Additional Documentation May Be Required
- Review the instructions for how to apply for a visa on the website of the U.S. Embassy or Consulate where you will apply. Additional documents may be requested to establish if you are qualified. For example, additional requested documents may include evidence of:
 - The purpose of your trip,
 - Your intent to depart the United States after your trip, and/or
 - Your ability to pay all costs of the trip.
- Evidence of your employment and/or your family ties may be sufficient to show the purpose of your trip and your intent to return to your home country. If you cannot cover all the costs for your trip, you may show evidence that another person will cover some or all costs for your trip.
- **Note:** Visa applicants must qualify based on their ties abroad/to their home country, rather than assurances from U.S. family and friends. A letter of invitation or Affidavit of Support is not needed to apply for a visitor visa. If you choose to bring a letter of invitation or Affidavit of Support to your interview, please remember it is not one of the factors used in determining whether to issue or deny the visa.

NOTE: Citizens of Canada and Bermuda generally do not need nonimmigrant visas for tourism.

5.Attend Your Visa Interview

A consular officer will interview you to determine whether you are qualified to receive a visitor visa. You must establish that you meet the requirements under U.S. law to receive a visa. Ink-free, digital fingerprint scans are taken as part of the application process. They are usually taken during your interview, but this varies based on location.

After your visa interview, the consular officer may determine that your application requires further administrative processing. The consular officer will inform you if this is required.

After the visa is approved, you may need to pay a visa issuance fee (if applicable to your nationality), and make arrangements for the return of the passport and visa to you.

6.Entering the United States

- A visa allows a foreign citizen to travel to a U.S. port-of-entry (generally an airport) and request permission to enter the United States. A visa does not guarantee entry into the United States. The Department of Homeland Security (DHS), U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials at the port-of-entry have authority to permit or deny admission to the United States. If you are allowed to enter the United States, the CBP official will provide an admission stamp or a paper Form I-94, Arrival/Departure Record. Learn more about admissions and entry

requirements, restrictions about bringing food, agricultural products, and other restricted/prohibited goods, and more by reviewing the [CBP website](#).

Extend Your Stay for visitor visa.

- A request for an extension of stay (EOS) is generally filed on a Petition for a Nonimmigrant Worker ([Form I-129](#)) or Application to Extend/Change Nonimmigrant Status ([Form I-539](#)), depending upon the nonimmigrant classification the petitioner or applicant seeks to extend.
- You may apply to extend your stay if:
- You were lawfully admitted into the United States with a nonimmigrant visa;
- Your nonimmigrant visa status remains valid;
- You have not committed any crimes that make you ineligible for a visa;
- You have not violated the conditions of your admission; and
- Your passport is valid and will remain valid for the duration of your stay.
- You may not apply to extend your stay if you were admitted to the United States in the following categories:
- Visa Waiver Program;
- Crew member (D nonimmigrant visa);
- In transit through the United States (C nonimmigrant visa);
- In transit through the United States without a visa (TWOV);
- Fiancé(e) of a U.S. citizen or dependent of a fiancé(e) (K nonimmigrant visa); or
- Informant (and accompanying family) on terrorism or organized crime (S nonimmigrant visa).

PERIOD OF STAY/EXTENSION OF STAY FOR B-1 VISA TYPE

Initial Period of Stay	Extension of Stay
1 to 6 months; 6 months is the maximum	Up to 6 months; maximum total amount of time permitted in B-1 status on any one trip is generally 1 year.

At the port of entry, an immigration official must authorize your admission to the United States, and, if you are eligible for admission, you may be admitted initially for the period necessary to carry out your business activities, up to a maximum period of 1 year. If you who wish to stay beyond the time indicated on the Form I-94 without departing from the United States, you must file Form I-539, Application to Extend/Change Nonimmigrant Status, and submit any required supporting documents to USCIS. For more